Startup Studio · Columbia University · Fall 2026

Build kickoff, landing pages, and traffic

Start building, get your page up, and start driving traffic

Class 5 · Friday, October 9, 2026 · 1:10 to 3:40 PM · Pupin 420

What we're doing today

1:10 PM

Homework 4

AI news, then your synthesis, style guides, logos, and Reddit research.

1:40 PM

Landing pages

Turn all of that into a homepage and a page for each value prop.

2:05 PM

MVP scope

What to build first, and a team exercise.

2:45 PM

Build kickoff

After a break: three rules, your framework, git, and your stack.

3:10 PM

Traffic

Where traffic comes from, free channels, and how to measure it.

The rest of the semester, 1 of 3

Date	Class	Topic	Homework due
Today	Class 5	Landing pages, traffic, build kickoff	HW 4: synthesis, personas, setup
Oct 16	Class 6	Driving traffic	HW 5: pages, demand plan, MVP doc
Oct 23	Class 7	MVP demos	HW 6: working MVP
Oct 30	Class 8	What to build next	HW 7: MVP learnings

The rest of the semester, 2 of 3

Date	Class	Topic	Homework due
Nov 6	Class 9	Get users and analytics	HW 8: roadmap and CLAUDE.md
Nov 13	Class 10	Cold start	HW 9: growth plan, analytics
Nov 20	Class 11	Showcase and fundraising	HW 10: cold start strategy
Nov 27	No class	Thanksgiving	

The rest of the semester, 3 of 3

Date	Class	Topic	Homework due
Dec 4	Class 12	Feature freeze and pitching	HW 11: iterate, then freeze
Dec 11	Class 13	Unit economics, deck workshop	HW 12: pitch deck draft 1
Dec 18	Demo Day	Final pitches and live demos	HW 13: final deck

What you work on next, and why

Next class, Oct 16

- Class 6: Driving traffic
- Homework 5: pages, demand plan, MVP doc
- Why it matters: Your copy is a guess until strangers see it. Traffic to a live page shows real demand.

After that, Oct 23

- Class 7: MVP demos
- Homework 6: working MVP
- Why it matters: Showing a working product to a room is the fastest way to find what is broken or confusing.

AI news this week

This week in AI

Which one do you want to talk about?

Robot fight club

California ordered a startup to stop caging people with a humanoid. The founder posted the order as a win.

The Rundown Robotics, Oct 5

Adobe, rebuilt by AI

One developer used coding agents to clone Photoshop, Premiere, and five more. Free and open source.

OMG! Ubuntu, Oct 2026 · GitHub

Data center backlash

Amazon dropped its secrecy deals with towns. Over 100 local data center bans are being weighed.

TechCrunch, Oct 3

Homework 4: what you made

Part 1

Reflection

What did you learn about AI by doing the synthesis yourself first?

Discussion

- What did the AI find that **you missed**?
- What did you notice that the **AI didn't**?
- Where did you **trust** the AI's read? Where didn't you?

2 to 3 teams share highlights, 2 to 3 minutes each.

In your words: where the AI fell short

- “the AI missed what we felt in the room.”
- “the AI put quotation marks around phrases from our paraphrased notes as if people had said them.”
- “Checking the notes helped us catch three places where the AI went too far.”

In your words: where the AI helped

- “We had lumped "trust" into one 4-of-5 pattern. The AI split it into two different problems”
- “a departure reminder might not have prevented Tristan’s lateness because he already left as soon as his lab ended.”
- “their deeper difficulty was not knowing where to begin or what to trust.”

Your style guide and logo

- How many rounds did it take to find a direction?
- What did you keep, and what did you kill?
- Does your logo hold up at favicon size?
- Does the style guide match your brand position?

Your logos







Your Reddit research

- What did strangers say that your interviews didn't?
- Did it change your pitch?
- Which quote went into your brand position?
- Which subreddits are your people in? You'll post there.

What you found on Reddit

Student sublets

“the hardest part of subletting in nyc was never finding listings, it's figuring out which ones are real”

r/NYCapartments

College applications

“I’m not looking for a shortcut. I’m willing to work extremely hard and prepare for this, but I need to find a financially realistic path.”

r/IntltoUSA

Finding your way indoors

“I circled the building three times before just going in it and indeed it was the main entrance.”

r/mildlyinfuriating

Landing pages

Part 2

What a landing page does, how to prompt for one, and what to build it with.

Landing pages

Now turn all of this into a landing page.

Your brand position, style guide,
and Reddit quotes are the inputs.

Landing pages

Start with one homepage. Then add a landing page for each value prop.

Your homepage and your landing pages

Homepage

- Your core marketing page
- Who it's for and the main promise
- One per product

Landing page

- One value prop, one audience
- One action: sign up
- One for each message you test

Posts and ads about one problem point to the landing page for that problem.

Best practices

A landing page is not a marketing homepage.

It has one job: drive a specific action.

Best practices for landing pages

Focus on one problem

- Name the specific pain point
- List how you solve it
- Have everything support this particular message

Clear call to action

- CTA = join the waitlist (that's it for now)
- Above the fold, obvious, impossible to miss
- Every section should lead back to it

Scannable and streamlined

- **Scannable in seconds:** a visitor should get it without reading every word
- **Streamline toward one action:** no nav bars, no "learn more,"
  no distractions

What we look for in a page critique

- Generic stock photos, default icons, and AI art slop
- Copy that doesn't match the brand position
- Missing or inconsistent use of the style guide
- A weak CTA or unclear value prop above the fold
- No social proof or credibility signals

How to prompt for a landing page

Don't mock it up first. Let the AI run with your docs.

The formula

BRIEF.md plus BRAND_POSITION.md plus STYLE_GUIDE.md, handed to a code agent. Then iterate.

Five prompt moves

01	**Give all three docs**	Your brief, brand position, and style guide, up front.
02	**Be specific**	Name the sections: hero, 3 benefit cards, testimonial, CTA.
03	**Use your values**	Use my primary color for the CTA button.
04	**Iterate**	Make the hero bolder. The spacing feels tight.
05	**Use an editor**	Comment on the page itself with LAHE. You need to be able to edit by hand.

Pages that don't look like AI slop

Icons, real photos, illustrations, and a logo.

Four tricks for a page that looks real



Icon library

Name one in your prompt.



Real photos

Send your agent to Pexels.



Illustrations

A prompt template, run in Gemini.



A logo

You made the mini process earlier.

Always name an icon library



Lucide

Clean line icons. Free, and no credit needed.



Font Awesome

Huge set. The free icons need a credit.



Heroicons

Made by the Tailwind team. No credit needed.

Say which one in your prompt. Otherwise you get emoji.

Lucide license · Font Awesome license · Heroicons license

Tell your agent to browse Pexels

- Ask it to search Pexels for photos that fit your product
- Real people and real places beat generic stock
- Free to use on a commercial page, no credit required
- Save each file and note the photographer anyway
- Never use a photo to suggest someone endorses you

Visuals for landing pages

AI illustration

A prompt in Gemini. Best for hero art and concept shots.

Stock photos

Real people and places. Pull them from Pexels.

Screenshots

Product demos and mockups, even before it exists.

HTML/CSS

Charts, graphics, and geometric patterns.

SVGs

New: Claude and Codex draw good icons and diagrams.

MVP scoping

Part 3

The two-week sprint

Scope your MVP to fit two weeks, with a landing page running alongside.



Fri Oct 9

Today

Define your MVP scope.

Fri Oct 16

Class 6

Pages live. MVP doc due.

Fri Oct 23

Class 7

MVP presentations.
Demo what you built.

Everything before this was validation. Now you ship.

MVP scoping

Your MVP is how you get your first real users.

User growth is 10% of your grade. B2B is fine if you can get those users on the product.

“[T]he minimum viable product is that version of a new product which allows a team to collect the maximum amount of validated learning about customers with the least effort.”

Eric Ries, "Minimum Viable Product: a guide," 2009

startuplessonslearned.com

What is an MVP?

- **Minimum** = least effort. **Viable** = delivers real value. Both matter.
- Not a prototype (tests usability). An MVP **tests the business hypothesis**.
- YC's Michael Seibel: hold the problem tightly, hold the solution loosely.

“If you're not embarrassed by the first version of your product, you've launched too late”

Reid Hoffman, X post, March 2017

x.com/reidhoffman/status/847142924240379904

MVP scoping

Your MVP is the shortest path to your user's first aha moment.

Your MVP = first aha moment

Your MVP

- The **ONE** core flow
- User arrives, does the thing, gets value
- Demo-able in 3 minutes

Not your MVP

- "All the features we validated"
- "Everything on our landing page"
- Settings, profiles, admin panels

If you can't demo it in 5 minutes, you've scoped too much.

MVP scoping

Wizard of Oz: it looks like a product. A person does the hard part behind the scenes.

Faking the hard part, in the wild

Three founders, in their own accounts.

01	**Zappos**	Faked the stock. The founder posted a local store's shoes online and bought a pair only after an order.
02	**Groupon**	Faked the software. A reskinned WordPress blog, coupons made in FileMaker, and PDFs sent by email.
03	**DoorDash**	The founders were the service. PDF menus, a landing page, their own phone, and they delivered orders.

Fortune, Swinmurn, Mixergy, Mason, Startup Archive, Tang

What can you fake?

Marketplaces

Manually match supply and demand behind the scenes.

Algorithms

Start with the most naive version, or do it by hand.

Data-heavy

Use LLMs and Decision models.

Social, matching

Seed with your team, friends, classmates.

MVP scoping

Any sufficiently advanced demo is indistinguishable from a product.

Let's build

Part 4

Work block: two tracks

Track A: Build

- Most of the team
- **Define your MVP scope**
- **Set up your dev environment**

Track B: Demand gen

- 1-2 people
- Landing page traffic **doesn't stop**
- Check analytics: visits, signups, drop-off
- Reddit and blog posts, outreach

Define your landing pages and MVP scope

Exercise, 15 minutes

15:00

1. Which 2 or 3 value props will you test? One landing page each.
2. What's the core flow? User, action, value.
3. What are you cutting, and what's faked?
4. Who's building what?
5. Fits in two weeks? If not, cut more.

Vibe coding is dead. Long live agentic engineering.

It was the best of vibes

Feb 2025

- “I 'Accept All' always, I don't read the diffs anymore.”

Feb 2026

- “personally my current favorite 'agentic engineering'”
- “the new default is that you are not writing the code directly 99% of the time, you are orchestrating agents who do and acting as oversight.”

Andrej Karpathy: founding member of OpenAI, former Sr. Director of AI at Tesla, Stanford PhD.

Karpathy on X, Feb 2, 2025, Karpathy on X, Feb 4, 2026

How we got here

Level 0

Manual

No AI assistance.

Level 1

Auto-complete

Tab to accept suggestions. Copilot, 2022.

Level 2

Chat-assisted

Ask questions in web chats, copy answers. ChatGPT, 2023.

Level 3

Vibe coding

Accept All, hope it works. Karpathy, Feb 2025.

Level 4

Agentic engi-neering

Orchestrate agents with human oversight. Karpathy, Feb 2026.

Level 5

Software factory

Many agents build in parallel from specs. Humans steer and review.

Vibe coding gets you a landing page. Agentic engineering gets you a product.

Three rules for the build phase

Part 5

Rule 1: The Willison rule

> Simon Willison
>
> “If an LLM wrote the code for you, and you then reviewed it, tested it thoroughly and made sure you could explain how it works to someone else that’s not vibe coding, it’s software development.”

Class rule: Don't deploy code you can't understand.

Simon Willison, "Not all AI-assisted programming is vibe coding (but vibe coding rocks)," Mar 19, 2025

Rule 2: Spec first, code second

Anthropic's guide

Claude Code's own docs. Explore, plan, then code. Skip the plan for tiny changes.

Harper Reed

Former CTO, Obama 2012 campaign. spec.md, blueprint, execute.

Addy Osmani

Engineering leader, Google Chrome. Write requirements first, before code.

Kent Beck

Creator of TDD and Extreme Programming. Red, green, refactor.

Which framework did you pick?

Homework 4 asked every team to pick one.

- Which one, and what did you compare it to?
- What made you pick it?
- What worries you about it?

Feature-forge: phases 1 to 3

My workflow, open source. Seven phases. Others use different steps.

Feature brief

Define the problem.

Architecture

Design the solution.

Plan

Break it into phases.

Feature-forge: phases 4 to 7

Implement

Write code and tests.

Review

Structured code review.

Push

PR, CI/CD, and deploy.

Cleanup

Measure and improve.

The documentation stack: 4 documents per feature

One example

01_brief

What and why? Goal, user stories, requirements, success metrics, non-goals.

02_architecture

How? Components, data flows, alternatives considered and rejected, edge cases.

03_plan

In what order? Phased tasks, test list, definition of done.

04_progress

What's happening? A living log of done, remaining, and results.

Stop gates: human approval

One example

After brief

Problem defined correctly?
Success metrics right?
Building the right thing?

After architecture

Design make sense?
Alternatives considered?
Missing edge cases?

After plan

Build order logical? Tests cover requirements? Ready to go?

Rule 3: CLAUDE.md is your team's brain

What it is

- Persistent context file in your repo root
- Claude reads it at the start of **every session**
- Your project's identity: stack, conventions, structure

How to use it

- Keep it short. Cut anything the agent can figure out
- Check it into git. It compounds in value
- When Claude does something wrong, **add a note**
- Template on the one-sheet

“Anytime we see Claude do something incorrectly we add it to the CLAUDE.md”

Boris Cherny, X post, January 2026

x.com/bcherny/status/2007179840848597422

Git for teams

With **2-4 people coding**, this prevents chaos:

- **Don't push to main directly.** Feature branches + PRs.
- **One feature per branch.** One AI session per branch.
- **Pull before you branch.** Commit often. Small PRs.
- **Someone reviews every PR.** Read the code, don't just check that tests pass.

Git for agents

Worktrees let agents build in parallel without colliding.

- A **worktree** is a second folder of the same repo, on its own branch
- Give each agent its own worktree
- Agents never edit the same files at the same time
- Each one merges back through a pull request

git worktree add ../myapp-login -b login

The recommended stack

Frontend

React or Next.js. A modern UI framework.

Backend

Supabase. Database, auth, and APIs.

Hosting

Railway. Auto-deploys from GitHub.

Version control

GitHub. Your team workflow.

TypeScript and Rust are what people reach for with agents now.

Code agents and what they cost

Tool	Price	Student path
Claude Code	$20 a month, or $17 yearly	No student price
GitHub Copilot Student	Free	Verified students
Codex	Free in ChatGPT	Go plan is $8
Cursor	$20 a month	No student plan listed
Lovable (no code)	$25 a month	50% off with student email

Checked Oct 1, 2026: Claude, GitHub, OpenAI, Cursor, Lovable

Where to host your MVP

Deploy early. The first deploy always finds problems.

Host	Cost	Watch out for
Railway	$5 a month, $5 usage	Usage above $5 is billed
Cloudflare Pages	Free	500 builds a month
Supabase database	Free tier	Pauses after a week idle
Vercel	Free Hobby plan	Non-commercial use only

Checked Oct 1, 2026: Railway, Cloudflare, Supabase, Vercel

Where traffic comes from

Part 6

The channel landscape

Paid

Money buys attention. Social ads about $0.70 a click, search ads about $5.42. Influencers.

Earned

Quality earns amplification. Word of mouth, referrals, press. Hardest to control, highest trust.

Owned

Effort compounds. Organic social, email list, content and SEO. Free, and it builds over time.

Social media: where organic reach still works

TikTok	More interaction per follower than other platforms, in one 70M-post study.
Instagram	Posts reach about 3 to 4% of followers.
LinkedIn profiles	People trust people. Post as a person.
Reddit	Answer real questions in your niche. Be a member first.

Socialinsider · Sprout Social

Where organic reach is dying

LinkedIn company pages	People engage with people more than with brands.
Instagram	Average reach is down 12% year over year.

Company pages are dead. Post as yourself, not as the company.

Organic social

Be a founder posting about your startup, not a startup posting about itself.

Your own profile is your first distribution channel. People follow people.

Community and launch channels

Reddit and niche groups

- Find the subreddits where your users already talk
- Be a genuine member first. Reddit punishes self-promotion.
- AMAs are effective for founders

Product Hunt

- Traffic spikes early, so have a signup form ready
- One shot, so make it count
- Better for your MVP launch than for today

How to use Reddit (without getting banned)

01	**Find 2-3 subreddits**	Search Reddit for your problem space. Join active ones.
02	**Participate first**	Answer questions and share insights for 1 to 2 weeks. Don't pitch yet.
03	**Share when relevant**	Someone asks about your problem? "I'm building X to solve this, here's the waitlist."
04	**Or post an AMA**	"I'm building X for Y problem. Here's what I learned interviewing 10 users."

Blog content builds long-term SEO

Problem-focused	5 reasons college students struggle with internships
Founder journey	What I learned from 10 user interviews
Solution explainer	How we're fixing X problem
Tactical advice	A guide to something your audience needs

Where to publish

Your own site	Best for SEO and owning the traffic
Medium or Substack	Built-in audience discovery
LinkedIn articles	Native reach to your network
Dev.to or Hashnode	If you're building for developers

Content

Distribution is more important than perfection.

Write one post and share it everywhere. A good post shared in 5 places beats 5 posts shared nowhere.

Channels feed each other

01	**Paid to email**	Paid ads drive traffic to your page. Some convert. Others join your list.
02	**Social lowers cost**	Organic social builds awareness. People click on names they recognize, so ads get cheaper.
03	**Email to referrals**	Nurture your list. Convert when your product is ready. Happy users tell friends.

This is a system, not a checklist.

Name your traffic owners today

- 1 or 2 people own traffic, **every week**
- Start your Reddit and blog posts **this week**
- Check analytics each week and tell the team
- Everyone else builds

Don't stop driving traffic just because you're building.

Plan your traffic

Exercise, 10 minutes

10:00

1. Who owns traffic every week?
2. Which 2 or 3 communities? Start with your Reddit research.
3. Your first 3 posts this week, and which landing page each one links to.
4. One blog post you could write now.

Measure your traffic

Part 7

Put Google Analytics on your page

01	**Account**	Create one at analytics.google.com.
02	**Property**	Add a property and a Web data stream.
03	**Tag**	Add the Google tag to every page. Your agent can do it.
04	**Signup event**	Fire it on the thank-you page. Mark it a key event.
05	**Check**	Open Realtime and visit your own page.

What to watch every week

- **Visitors:** is anyone coming?
- **Source:** where did they come from?
- **Signups:** how many, from which page?
- Tag every link you post with a **UTM**, in lowercase.

Homework and what's next

What's due Friday, October 16

Homepage	Live at a public URL, with email capture.
Landing pages	At least 3, one value prop each.
Demand strategy	Traffic owners, communities, and your first posts.
Analytics	Google Analytics on every page. Start Analytics Academy.
MVP defined	Core flow, what's cut, what's faked, who builds what.

Homework: your homepage and landing pages

- A homepage: who it's for and the main promise
- At least 3 landing pages, one value prop and one audience each
- One clear call to action and a working email signup on every page
- Your style guide, your icon library, and real imagery
- Every page live at a public URL

Homework: your demand strategy

A plan for traffic, and the first posts out. No ads yet.

- Your traffic owners, by name
- 2 or 3 communities, from your Reddit research
- Your first 3 posts, each linking to a landing page with a UTM
- One blog post, planned or published

Homework: analytics on the page

- Google Analytics on your pages, with signup as a key event
- A thank-you page that fires after signup
- Lowercase UTMs on every link you post
- Start Analytics Academy 101 and 102

Homework: define your MVP

- **Core flow:** user, action, value
- **Cut:** what you are not building
- **Faked:** your Wizard of Oz parts
- **Stack:** your framework, agent, and hosting
- **Roles:** who builds what, who owns traffic

How to submit by Friday, October 16

Due at the start of class. Open a pull request, then paste its link into Courseworks.

- Folder: teams/your-team/hw5-pages-demand-mvp/
- A README with the URL of every page
- demand_strategy.md and mvp_doc.md
- A note that you started Analytics Academy

Homework 6: your working MVP

What	When
Working MVP	Friday, October 23, 1:10 PM
5-minute demo	Ready for class 7

How to submit

- Put your work in teams/your-team-name/hw6-mvp/.
- Open one pull request per team. Paste the link into Courseworks.
- Add your MVP link and a short demo plan.

Podcasts this week

Demand gen

- Paid vs. earned vs. organic
- Goes deeper on everything today

LLM tools landscape

- Web portals, code portals, local agents
- Background for the build phase

Both are on the course site. Listen before next class.

The countdown to MVP

Landing page

1

week until it is due and live, on October 16

MVP

2

weeks until MVP presentations, on October 23

This week and next

Until October 16

- Landing page live, posts going out
- Build starts on your MVP
- October 16: driving traffic

October 16 to 23

- October 16: MVP doc due
- Keep building
- October 23: MVP presentations

Next Friday: driving traffic

- Landing page due and live
- Paid ads: your $100 test
- Start your Reddit and blog posts
- Build check-in: how is your MVP going?

Administrative note: Demo Day

Demo Day

Likely Friday, December 18, 12:00 to 3:00 PM, in the final exam slot. To be confirmed.

Questions?

Two weeks. Go build

Landing page live by next Friday. MVP by October 23.

Next class · Friday, October 16, 2026 · 1:10 to 3:40 PM · Pupin 420